melting snow and mud. Both the terrorists were killed in the shootout that followed their suicidal attack. Once again I appeared to be the target, and was lucky to survive. There were no other casualties. Captain Shakeel Ahmad and a few others from 8 Bihar were decorated with gallantry awards for this operation. Till this day I have not been able to fathom the reason for the terrorists' refusal of my offer of a safe passage.

I cannot help writing about a notorious terrorist guide, Fatta Sheikh, from Maiyan village, close to the LoC in the Lachhipura sector. In an operation conducted in Baramulla area, we apprehended a suspect hiding in a cattleshed. Inside that dark shed there were scores of sheep huddled together. It would have been impossible to spot someone lying on the floor, but for the ingenious method devised by a JCO of 2/11 GR. He got hold of a long bamboo pole and started combing the shed by sliding it along the floor. At one place it hit some obstruction and he realized that there was someone hiding there. He warned in a loud voice that he would shoot if the person didn't come out. Lo and behold! a man stood up with his hands raised. He was taken to the CO, who asked him a few questions. Fatta Sheikh's alibi was that he was a gujjar (a nomadic tribe of herdsmen) and that it was his occupation to take the cattle of various owners for grazing in the higher reaches of the mountains every summer. He told his captors that he had come to return the cattle and take his wages from the villagers. He was innocent and he hid himself in the cattleshed out of fear, because of the army crackdown.

The CO was not aware of his background and was about to let him go. I was informed about it, but the circumstances under which he was caught rang a bell. When I was told that his name was Fatta Sheikh, I enquired if he was from Maiyan village. 'Positive,' said the CO. Then I told the colonel that we had been looking for this man for almost a year. He was a notorious crook and a mercenary who had guided more than thirty terrorist groups across the LoC. He was a storehouse of information regarding infiltrators and their Pakistani